

five to 20 top applications in various categories such as 'Top Paid', 'Top Free', 'Top Grossing', 'Staff Picks', 'Recommended For You', 'Trending', etc. leaves room for only a few thousand applications to be discovered. If we closely analyse Google Play and other third-party Android app stores, they are not perfect mobile app discovery platforms yet. In the current system, developers upload app screenshots and app videos to showcase their applications on the app market. Based on the visual appeal and the description, products are sold. Now this certainly is not the perfect way of buying new apps. I mean, if you ask me to explain the current app store policy in simple terms, I would say they are selling us clothes based on their description, pictures, colours, designer, brand—and we can't try them on unless we buy them. Does that make sense? As a substitute to this, Google Play provides a window of 15 minutes for users to try the app and cancel the purchase if required. But this includes downloading the app, which is time-consuming.

Another issue with the current mobile app ecosystem is converting Web leads into actual downloads. On an average, 160 minutes/day are spent on the Internet using laptops and desktops, which is approximately 150 per cent of the mobile Internet usage. But the current app store system fails to use this platform efficiently. As explained in [image 2], app sharing on the Web is broken. We can see this if we compare the app-sharing lifecycle to the YouTube video-sharing lifecycle. How many of us actually go on YouTube searching for a video? To go by stats, 500 years of YouTube video are watched every day on Facebook, and over 700 YouTube videos are shared on Twitter each minute. A 100 million people take a social action on YouTube (such as likes, share, comment, etc) every week, out of a total 200 million users. So almost 50 per cent of the traffic is via social networking sites. Imagine going on YouTube and searching for the Korean popstar Psy's 'Gangnam' video based on a tweet or post saying, "hilarious dance steps guys, please go and download this video!" We are still lagging behind in the social recommendation model for mobile applications. Link sharing is similar to videos, but then actual consumption of content is broken until we download it. In other words, Web links fail to convince users effectively.

But there are quite a few products that try to solve this problem of app discovery; I have mentioned a few of these in Table 1. They add their own algorithms in addition to the Google Play algorithm, with extended social sharing features. That makes app discovery a bit hassle-free, and they do some kind of personalisation to the suggestions and ranking algorithm they use while showing the results to you. But the core problem remains unresolved—users have to trust the content and static images, or at best, the videos of the applications.



Overview of current app discovery



Issues with app sharing on the Web



Current video sharing process on the Web

Product	Features
App.net	Static custom pages for apps Download via SMS and email Better social sharing
AppHero	Good social recommendation Personalised app recommendation
Crosswalk	Social recommendation Personalised app recommendation Good app search
BuzzDoes	Social and personal recommendation Gives incentives to the users Developer needs to integrate their SDK

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